



Good mates: Good mates: Since getting a duck in the season opener against Delhi Capitals, whenever Shashank feels dejected, Jonny Bairstow's words echo in his mind: "If I don't see you smiling, I will stop speaking with you." SPORTSPICS / IPL

Tambe at D.Y. Patil (in Mumbai's corporate leagues) and have seen him debut in the IPL and in Ranji in his 40s," Shashank says. "And I have a friend in Surya (Suryakumar Yadav) with whom I have been playing for Parsee Gymkhana for the last 15 years."

Shashank emphasises the Suryakumar example, noting how both he and SKY excel at turning high-risk shots into calculated risks with precision, especially under pressure. "The world sat up and took notice when Surya hit Jofra Archer for a six off his first ball in

international cricket, but I had been watching him do the same for well over a decade, so I knew he would do it. Similarly, I know what I am capable of, and I support my abilities."

Being the mature individual he is, on and off the field, Shashank doesn't require pep talks from mentors. He gleans pointers from short conversations as adeptly as he reads a bowler's wrist — it could be with former India cricketer Abey Kuruvilla or his head coach at one of his earlier teams, SRH, Brian Lara.

"We miss him (Kuruvilla) at DY

Patil since he is with BCCI now, but he calls and shares his observations regularly," said Shashank. "And he (Brian) texted me the other day to compliment me, and we had a short chat."

Even Punjab Kings head coach Trevor Bayliss and director Sanjay Bangar are no exceptions. Just before the KKR game, Bangar and Shashank bumped into each other over breakfast. "All he told me was to be careful about a specific ball that Sunil Narine bowls, and I kept it in mind. Even Trevor — we had this meet and greet event with the fans, and someone was late by a couple of minutes — so in those two minutes, Trevor had a suggestion about a drive I played, and that's about it,"